Rage or love?

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37128097.

Rating:
Not Rated

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst, Hurt/Comfort, Friends to Lovers, Enemies to Lovers, Angst with a Happy Ending, i swear the ending is happy this time, Catra is not having a good time, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - College/University, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, POV Catra (She-Ra), Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra)

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by funny_little_frog

Summary

Modern AU
Adora and Catra have grown up together at the Horde Military Academy- but when Adora decides to leave, will Catra ever be able to forgive her? And when Catra receives orders to kill Adora, will she be able to go through with it...

Adora glanced to where their hands were joined.
"You would do that for me?" Her voice was soft. Tentative.
"Adora. I would do anything for you."
And the scariest thing, Catra realised, was that she meant it.
She truly would do anything for her.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Catra wasn't used to feeling so out of place.

Actually, no, scratch that. She absolutely was used to feeling so out of place. What she wasn't used to was this unfamiliar feeling resting just on top of it that she had been so far refusing to acknowledge- and quite successfully, she might add. Adora had been Catra's best friend since childhood- they had practically grown up together at the Horde Military Academy, but ever since Adora decided to leave in order to attend a regular university there had been a rift between them.

A rift that had grown wider with each passing day.

Sure, they had kept in touch with regular emails, but there was a sort of cold emptiness resting in the very pit of Catra's stomach.

Adora had *left* her.

And now here she was, meeting all of Adora's friends as though not a day had passed.

"Hey, Catra," said Adora brightly, handing her a drink. She was dressed in simple trousers and a soft lilac sweater that set off her sparkling blue eyes, which sent an unwelcome thrill down Catra's spine- she was still unused to seeing Adora outside of the regulation training uniform they had worn every day as cadets in the Academy. "You okay there? You're looking kinda lost."

Catra glanced briefly over to where two of Adora's friends- a girl with choppy pink hair and a boy with a shirt that displayed most of his midriff- were laughing over a shared joke. A joke which Adora was also in on, no doubt. Catra had to swallow down the rising bile in her throat.

Why did she agree to come here?

"Yeah, just, you know. Getting used to finally meeting your friends, I guess." Catra didn't even try to keep the sting out of her words, and she was rewarded with a brief flash of hurt in Adora's

eyes. So why did the knowledge that she had caused Adora even the slightest bit of pain feel far from satisfying, even after Adora had left her? It felt like a physical blow to the gut.

"Yeah, they're amazing." Adora gazed affectionately over to her friends, adoration clearly visible in her eyes. "That's Bow over there talking to Glimmer, he's a history major and he's on the uni archery team, I reckon he could make it pro if he wanted. And Glimmer's studying physics…"

Catra tuned her out, taking the opportunity to study Adora properly, her eyes lingering on the way some loose strands of blonde hair had escaped from her ponytail. She had to fight down the urge to reach over and tuck them behind her ear.

The most wonderful thing, Catra had to admit, was Adora herself. Back when they were cadets Adora had always carried a sort of light around her, as though her mere presence could illuminate the dull, ceaseless gloom of the underground tunnel-system which constituted the Academy's base of operations. Or at least, that was how it had seemed to Catra. Her entire world had always been dark, and Adora was the only one who had ever been able to hold a light up to all that darkness.

But then Adora had left, and she took the light with her.

"Catra?" Adora prompted, dragging her out of her thoughts. Her expectant expression indicated that she had asked something that required a response. *Shit.*

"Uh, yeah. Absolutely. Sorry, one sec. Be right back." Catra all but stumbled over herself in her rush to find the nearest available exit, and she ducked into the corridor with tears welling in her eyes. She swiped at them angrily, hissing in frustration under her breath.

Why was this happening to her?

She took a few deep breaths, relishing the comparatively quiet stillness of the corridor. The cool, sharp press of wood from the

door jamb bit into her palm, the pain grounding her more than anything ever could.

Anything… apart from perhaps one person.

"Hey, Catra." Adora's voice came from just behind Catra's shoulder, accompanied by the gentle, tentative pressure of her hand. "I know it's been months since I left, and I'm sorry I didn't reach out sooner. It just felt so strange to finally be away, and I guess I just needed the time but I'm honestly so sorry, I-"

"You left me!" The words ripped out of Catra as though being torn from her by force. A harsh, ripping sound punctuated the sentence, and she noted with a strange sense of detachment that it was her own sob. "You know how Shadow Weaver treated me, you know what happened, you're the *only one* who knew and you still left me there! In that *place.*" Catra spat the last word, tears clinging to her eyelashes and threatening dangerously to fall. Shadow Weaver was the nickname they had given their superior, and even the thought of her made a particularly nasty bruise on Catra's ribs throb painfully, as though it were protesting against any reminders of the person who put it there.

Adora took a step back, her eyes widening with pity and… *remorse?* Fuck. Catra didn't need her to feel sorry for her. That was the last thing she wanted.

"Catra, I'm… I asked you if you wanted to come with me?"

Catra laughed hollowly, the lack of emotion in her own voice scaring even her. "I don't belong here."

And with that she spun on her heel, walking out into the cool night, ignoring the slow fracturing of her heart at the muffled sound of Adora's sob.

Later that night, Catra lay in bed, tossing and turning in the Academy barracks. The rhythmic snoring of Lonnie and Kyle in the

bunks next to her did nothing to help lull her to sleep; her palms were sweaty and she couldn't stop replaying what she had said to Adora earlier. Deep down, Catra had known what the pressure was doing to her best friend. As Force Captain, Adora had shouldered the brunt of the responsibility, constantly subjecting herself to Shadow Weaver's disapproval. And it wasn't only that- if Catra knew anything about Adora, it was that her entire sense of self-worth originated from being able to serve. And sure, that mindset was almost entirely drilled into her in the first place by the Horde Military Academy, particularly the fucking piece of shit Shadow Weaver, but Catra had seen that there was only so much more of the indiscriminate acts of violence comitted and even *encouraged* at the Academy that Adora could take. And, selfishly, Catra had refused to acknowledge it, out of a childish hope that it could somehow stop Adora from ever leaving.

Well, just look how well that turned out, thought Catra bitterly.

She rolled over, slamming a pillow over head and screwing her eyes shut. And this time, the ensuing darkness was not wholly unwelcome.

"Again." Catra motioned impatiently for Rogelio to get up from where he was lying spread-eagled on the training mat.

"Catra, we've been at it for ages. Lonnie and Kyle left almost an hour ago! Can't we take a break?" Rogelio wiped blood from his lip, blinking owlishly up at Catra with laboured breathing.

"I'm Force Captain now, Rogelio. What I say goes." The sharpness of her own voice surprised her, but she refused to let her expression waver. She *would* earn the respect she deserved. The respect she was long overdue.

"Catra." A voice behind her made her stiffen, every nerve in her body going on high alert.

“Shadow Weaver.” Catra slowly turned around, appraising the tall, imposing figure of the woman in front of her.

“You’re dismissed, Rogelio,” said Shadow Weaver with a dismissive flick of her hand, and Rogelio promptly scurried from the room with a poorly disguised squeak of terror.

“Where were you yesterday, Catra? My sources told me that you didn’t show up for yesterday’s debrief. Now, why could that be? It seems like only yesterday that you were practically begging me to promote you to Force Captain, and now I see you are already beginning to forget your duties?”

The tips of Catra’s ears reddened. “I was… out,” she replied vaguely, hoping that Shadow Weaver would end this specific line of questioning.

“You were visiting Adora, weren’t you?” A vindictive smile played around Shadow Weaver’s lips.

Catra blanched. “Uhh-”

“Well, no matter.” Shadow Weaver steepled her fingers under her chin, a gesture which Catra had learned to associate with fear. “I guess your visit had its benefits. It gave you a chance to scout out the surroundings of your next mission.”

Within a single heartbeat of this statement, Catra felt the blood flow right out of her body, her limbs going cold and leaden with dread. “My next mission?” she asked, hating herself for the tremble in her voice.

“Adora left the Academy in disgrace. As a former Force Captain, she was told many military secrets in the strictest of confidence- but now, as she is no longer in my control, we cannot guarantee her silence. And that is why your next mission is to *take Adora out.*”

Each of those last three words may as well have been punctuated with a blow to Catra’s heart.

“But I can’t just… she’s *Adora*… she-”

“Silence.” Shadow Weaver raised a bony hand, cutting off Catra mid-sentence. “You *will* do as I ask, or I suppose we will have to have a little talk about that badge you wear so proudly on your chest.”

The shiny Force Captain badge pinned to Catra’s shirt seemed to weigh a little heavier at those words. And Catra knew exactly what this *talk* would entail; most likely stripping her of her rank and a few shiny fresh bruises.

“Yes, Shadow Weaver” Catra mumbled, looking downwards at her feet.

The rage that she normally carried inside her since Adora had left, fuelling her and keeping her warm, had entirely dissipated. All she felt now was the cold, hollow sense of emptiness and defeat.

“You can’t eat all my ration bars, Catra!” said Scorpia indignantly, snatching the half eaten brown lump from Catra’s grasp as they both sat with their backs against the wall of the laundry room. For the past few weeks, they had both been meeting here to eat- it was warm, and Scorpia was good company. Most of the time. And as a bonus, it was away from the prying eyes and ears of the rest of the Academy.

“Hey,” Catra protested half-heartedly, lacking the energy to put up any proper form of resistance.

“Listen, I come from royalty, kitten. I deserve all the ration bars I want.” Catra almost smiled at the affectionate nickname and dry sarcasm in Scorpia’s voice. Almost. “Also, in other news, did you see Adora snooping around here earlier? I would’ve sworn I saw her round the barracks.”

Catra froze.

"What? Wait what? You saw Adora here? *Here?* In the Academy? And you're only mentioning this now?"

Scorpia's eyebrows scrunched together in confusion and she opened her mouth to respond, but Catra didn't stay long enough to hear what she had to say.

Hurtling down the corridors and bursting through a crowd of young, fresh-faced new recruits, Catra skidded to a stop outside the room she shared with Lonnie and Kyle, breathing hard. And sure enough, Adora was sitting on her old bed- *Catra's* bed, now- grinning as she chatted with Lonnie as though not a day had passed.

What was she *doing?* It wasn't safe for her to be here. Shadow Weaver wanted her dead.

"What are you doing here?" Catra hissed, trying and failing to keep her voice to a whisper. Adora whipped around, her blonde ponytail swinging and her blue eyes widening.

"Hey, Catra." Adora's face morphed into a smile- and it was like the sun emerging from behind a cloud.

"What are you doing here?" Catra repeated, stepping into the room and closing the door gingerly behind her after Lonnie slipped out, excusing herself with a mumble.

"I didn't like how we left things the other night." Adora's voice was firm and she held Catra's gaze unwaveringly. *This* was the strength that had made her Shadow Weaver's favourite from the start. That had got her promoted to Force Captain.

And Catra did what she always did. She lashed out.

"Fuck you, Adora. You don't *get* to decide how we end things. Don't you see? I chose my side, and you chose yours. And if your allegiance is not with the Academy, well then your allegiance is not with me. You left. You made that choice, not me. And now

you have to live with the consequences of your own decision. If you can't handle that, it's not my problem."

Adora's expression didn't waver. "My allegiance will always be with you, Catra. Even if I no longer have any ties to this place, it doesn't mean I ever want to cut my ties with *you*." The earnestness of Adora's words made all the fight leave Catra in a dizzying rush.

"Oh," breathed Catra softly. She gingerly sat on the edge of the bed, leaving a few feet of space between them. The faint scent of the apple shampoo that Adora always used enveloped her in a comforting cloud of memories and something that was purely just *Adora.* 'You mean-"

Adora laughed. "Catra, you're my best friend. How could you ever have thought that I wanted to leave you?"

Catra frowned, something about those words not sitting right with her. Adora reached across the gap between them, placing her hand reassuringly on Catra's own. Her hand was warm and soft and Catra could feel every point of contact between them buzzing with energy. It was something electric. Alive.

"Come with me," Adora murmured, her voice barely rising above a whisper. "Come back with me."

Catra wished she had asked for anything, anything, but that. Because she would never be able to go with Adora, no matter how much her heart longed for it.

"Everything has changed," Catra replied, "since you were last here. I got promoted to force captain. My uniform changed. *I* changed. And if I couldn't go with you before, I definitely can't now. You think that I can just leave, but I can't. Everything has changed," Catra repeated, looking urgently into Adora's eyes, begging her to understand the words she had left unspoken. Was it just her, or were they closer than before?

"Come with me," Adora replied stubbornly.

“Did you not hear-?”

“Come with me.”

“No.”

“Come with me.” Adora’s voice was barely a whisper, her warm breath tickling Catra’s cheek. They were definitely closer than they were before.

“No, it’s-”

And they were kissing. Catra wasn’t quite sure which one of them had bridged the gap, but that didn’t matter anymore. Nothing mattered anymore apart from the feel of Adora’s lips of her own, the gentle press of her hand on Catra’s waist, the errant strands of Adora’s hair tickling against Catra’s cheek and finally, *finally,* being able to tuck them behind her ear. It was as if space and time ceased to exist and everything that had once troubled Catra fell away, tumbling into the void.

Everything apart from one thing.

“I have to kill you,” murmured Catra against Adora’s lips.

Adora’s breathing hitched and she pulled back, her brows narrowing into a frown. Catra felt the cold loss of her immediately, and she regretted those words ever coming out of her mouth.

“Uh, okay,” Adora replied, her mouth quirking into a small smile. “Let’s pretend for a moment that you actually *could* kill me if you wanted to. Why exactly do you have to do this?”

“First of all, I could totally best you in combat.” Catra was rewarded by Adora’s eyes narrowing with the challenge. The sight sent a small thrill through her. “You’re out of practice, you’ve been away for months!” Catra nudged Adora teasingly. But honestly… I had a conversation with Shadow Weaver the other day. She said something about you knowing a bunch of secrets that I guess she doesn’t want you to spill?” A small seed of curiosity took root in

Catra's chest- what were these secrets? Impatiently, she brushed the thought away. That wasn't important right now.

"Oh ," murmured Adora, looking down at her feet. "Oh, that."

Catra swallowed past the lump in her throat. How was it that just a moment ago they were kissing, and now this was happening?

"Adora, you have to run. You won't be safe from Shadow Weaver- you know as well as I do that she has spies everywhere. You have to go somewhere you'll be safe. Please, promise me this."

"I can't. My friends- I can't just leave them. Don't you see? I'm finally happy." Adora took Catra's hand between both of her own, and Catra tried to fight down the rising feeling of rejection in her chest. Sure, Adora was finally happy- in the life she had built for herself without Catra.

They sat that way for a measure of a few heartbeats, their chests rising and falling with the weight of the whole world on their shoulders.

Catra sat up suddenly. "Listen, Adora. I have a plan." Her breaths quickened with excitement. Yes, this could work. They could actually do this. "I could just tell Shadow Weaver that you're dead. I could *prove* it to her, so that way she wouldn't have any reason to send her spies snooping around you and your friends."

"But how?"

"I'll bring her a trophy. Something that only you have. Your old Force Captain badge, that might work?"

Adora glanced to where their hands were joined. "You would do that for me?" Her voice was soft. Tentative.

"Adora. I would do anything for you."

And the scariest thing, Catra realised, was that she meant it. She truly would do anything for her.

"I did it."

Catra stood in front of Shadow Weaver, her hands clasped behind her back and her chin defiantly upraised. Shadow Weaver appraised her soundlessly, her gaze scanning every inch of Catra from the tips of her black boots to the hood she had pulled over her head, and pursed her lips. Shadow Weaver's inky black hair fluttered ominously in the slight breeze wafting from the open window, like a sentient wraith. But of course not. That was just a purely fantastical manifestation of Catra's fears.

"And… what? I'm just supposed to take your word for it?"

Catra exhaled, pulling the badge from her pocket. "Here. It's Adora's Force Captain badge that she took with her when she left. And I took it from her by force when… when I killed her." She hoped that Shadow Weaver would overlook the way her voice trembled on those words.

"Hmm. I see."

Catra could hardly breathe, for fear of betraying the truth.

Because if Shadow Weaver knew that Catra was lying to her, it would be considered the highest act of treason; and Adora would most certainly be killed by another one of Shadow Weaver's minions. A minion who wouldn't question her orders, like Catra.

And Catra would *never* let that happen.

The next few seconds were the longest seconds that she had ever experienced.

"You're lying." Shadow Weaver's mouth twisted grotesquely with sinister amusement as she spoke these words.

Catra's breath hitched.

"I'm not! I swear!" Her excuse sounded weak even to her own ears.

"You're lying. You think I haven't seen the way you acted around her? The way you stepped aside to let her rise through the ranks without a single complaint? I know you, Catra. I raised you. You really thought you could hide your feelings towards Adora from me?" She laughed hollowly, the dry sound ringing through the room. "I waited. I waited for you to run to her when she left. I'm honestly surprised it took you so long. And this mission I gave you? To kill her? I knew you could never complete it. And now… well. Now I get to kill you."

Catra stepped back involuntarily. Her hand flew to the dagger she always wore strapped to her waist, concealed under her shirt, and she gripped the familiar metal hilt tightly. In the military, it was customary for cadets to carry guns, but Catra had always preferred the comfort and security that the feel of her trusty dagger at her waist gave her. Because guns could fail; blades could not.

Shadow Weaver's eyes tracked Catra's every movement, and they narrowed at the flash of bronze as Catra drew her weapon.

"What? You really think you can fight me, cadet? I trained you, Catra. I made you who you are. Don't you dare-"

Catra let the dagger fly.

It spun, glinting through the air, and embedded itself in-

Wood?

The place where Shadow Weaver had been standing just a moment ago was now empty space. The dagger quivered in the wall for the measure of a few heartbeats, and then fell into an eerie silence.

Well. Shit.

“I told you, Catra. You can’t fight me.”

“Like hell I can’t.” Catra gritted her teeth, launching a flying kick at Shadow Weaver. She wasn’t particularly surprised when the blow failed to land.

“Weak,” sneered Shadow Weaver, leering down at Catra. “Pathetic. I was a fool to think you would ever succeed here.”

“Fuck. You,” fought out Catra, trying and failing to land a blow. Shadow Weaver was deceptively fast, dodging Catra’s attacks with no apparent effort on her part.

Catra tried to distract Shadow Weaver with a feigned jab at her head followed by a round kick, but she stepped away easily. Almost too easily. She was *toying* with her.

Shadow Weaver chucked. “Child, you forget who taught you? You can’t best me.” And too fast for Catra to even understand how it happened, she was lying on the floor at Shadow Weaver’s feet with pain blooming from her ribs, erupting into a wildfire when she tried to take a breath. Her vision was shot through with hazy blotches, but it was enough to make out the imposing shape of Shadow Weaver edging closer.

“You are worth *nothing* to me,” said Shadow Weaver, kicking Catra sharply in the ribs even as she struggled to get up. She would not go down without a fight.

But kick after kick, Catra began to wonder why she was struggling. It was clear that Shadow Weaver had sent her after Adora just to get under her skin and to have some leverage against her, so if she let Shadow Weaver kill her, it seemed logical that Adora would be free.

And that was just about all that Catra cared about.

“Kill me, then,” choked Catra through the coppery tang of blood in her mouth.

“Oh, I will,” chuckled Shadow Weaver sinisterly, her silhouette looming closer. And was it just Catra’s failing eyes, or was there another shadow just behind Shadow Weaver?

A shape that looked strangely like…

“Hey, Adora,” Catra breathed. She was rewarded with the alarmed widening of Shadow Weaver’s eyes before the figure- Adora- embedded Catra’s abandoned dagger right into Shadow Weaver’s gut.

“Hey, Catra,” said Adora in her familiar lilting voice. A voice like sunlight. "Told ya I could best you in combat." And just before Catra’s vision faded to black, she felt the warmth flooding back into her limbs; a warmth that could only ever come from Adora.

Adora.

And she knew then, with absolute certainty, that they would be okay. Everything would be okay, because Adora came back for her.

They would be okay.

End Notes

okay i swear catra isn't dead she's just briefly unconscious!!! she will wake up and they will live happily ever after <3

also this was literally supposed to be a cute college AU spin the bottle fic for valentines' day??? why did so much angst happen. who knows? certainly not me.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!